Chapter 1

Data Compression and Decompression

Data compression and decompression are fundamental techniques used in modern computing, enabling efficient storage and transmission of data. The concept of entropy, borrowed from the field of information theory, plays a crucial role in determining the compression rate.

1.1 Data Compression and Decompression

Data compression is the process of reducing the amount of data needed to represent a particular set of information. The two main types of data compression are lossless and lossy. Lossless compression ensures that the original data can be perfectly reconstructed from the compressed data, whereas lossy compression allows some loss of data for more significant compression rates. Decompression is the reverse process of compression, reconstructing the original data from the compressed format.

1.2 Entropy

In information theory, entropy measures the unpredictability or randomness of information content. More specifically, it quantifies the expected value of the information contained in a message. Lower entropy implies less randomness and more repetitiveness, which in turn means the data can be compressed more.

1.3 Entropy and Compression

The role of entropy in data compression is fundamental. The entropy of a source of data is the minimum number of bits required, on average, to encode symbols drawn from the source. It serves as a lower bound on the best possible lossless compression rate.

For a source X with probability distribution $p(x)$, the entropy $H(X)$ is defined as:

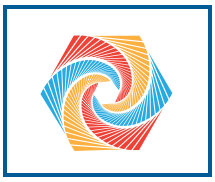
$$H(X) = -\sum_{x \in X} p(x) \log_2 p(x) \tag{1.1}$$

If the entropy of the data is high (i.e., the data is random and unpredictable), the potential for compression is low. On the other hand, if the entropy is low (the data is predictable), the data can be compressed to a smaller size.

This is a draft chapter from the Kontinua Project. Please see our website (https://kontinua.org/) for more details.

Appendix A

Answers to Exercises



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